

seeker. Here, Aatish is explaining his Aakash-complex to the "writer", whose resemblance to V.S. Naipaul is not a caricature but an appreciation. The writer, provoked, has been debunking the left-liberal clichés on secularism and communalism by going back to the vandalised civilisation and the history of invasions—and the wholeness of Indian cultural heritage. "In fact, it could be said that there is almost no other country, certainly not one so vast, where the countrymen are as acquainted with the distant reaches of the land through their pilgrimages as they are in India; perhaps no country where poor people travel more. They think nothing of jumping on a bus or train, for two or three days, to journey to Tirupathi in the south or Jagannath in the east. And this way, the religion itself is like a form of patriotism." It is the India of Aakash; it's the India where Aatish hates to be a stranger.

Still, it is not sociology alone that provides the frisson to *The Temple-Goers*, though the relentless argument between competing ideas of India—of tradition and modernity—reaches no resolution in this novel. It is a very physical book as well, swelling with passions. Aatish, the storyteller, is in Delhi, the city of his mother and his girlfriend, Sanyogita, to revise his first novel. Just hours after his arrival, he moves into his girlfriend's flat in Jorbagh. The axis of his existence shifts once his relationship with his trainer grows beyond the gym floor, into a Delhi of "rich and poor people, of Bentleys and bicycles, of government flats and mansions, of hookers and heiresses". His discovery of Aakash—and eventually his submission to him—runs parallel to the slow disintegration of his life with Sanyogita, who can't compete with the "other intimacies" in his life. Characters like his Urdu teacher who lives in the dispossessed remoteness of old Delhi and the Dunhill-smoking Maharani chief minister who uses his mother's flat to meet her lover make Aatish's homecoming a permanent astonishment, culminating in a murder mystery starring Aakash. Once again, it is his virtuosity in moving between the "varied lives" of his nativity that brings the sexual and the sociological, the political and the emotional, to a combustible finale.

*The Temple-Goers* may be set in the Delhi of Holi parties where fashion designers brag about making models out of hot little country boys of Punjab, of literary salons of aspiring writers, of *jagrans* and communal stereotyping. It is also a novel in which the biography of the novelist is as overwhelming as his imagination. Still, this is not just a Delhi novel, though some brilliant set pieces capture the Capital manners in all its class extremes. Written in a language that announces the arrival of one of the finest stylists in fiction, *The Temple-Goers* is one man's story of liberation. As you turn the last page, you realise Aatish has all along been revising the tensions and temptations of his inheritance, like any good storyteller. ■

## TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

### FICTION

1. *2 States: The Story of My Marriage*  
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
2. *Dork: The Incredible Adventures of Robin 'Einstein' Varghese*  
Sidin Vadukut, Penguin
3. *The Lost Symbol*  
Dan Brown, Bantam Press
4. *Now that You're Rich... Let's fall in love*  
Durjoy Datta and Maanvi Ahuja, Srishti
5. *Oh Shit, Not Again!*  
Mandar Kokate, Expression

### NON-FICTION

1. *You can Sell*  
Shiv Khera, Rupa
2. *Discover the Diamond in You*  
Arindam Chaudhuri, Vikas
3. *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*  
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
4. *Stay Hungry Stay Foolish*  
Rashmi Bansal, CII-EIIM
5. *The Difficulty of Being Good: On the Subtle Art of Dharma*  
Gurcharan Das, Penguin

### OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

### FICTION

8. *I Too had a Love Story*  
Ravinder Singh, Srishti
9. *Devil in Pinstripes*  
Ravi Subramanian, Rupa
11. *Five Point Someone*  
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa

### NON-FICTION

6. *Simply Fly: A Deccan Odyssey*  
Captain Gopinath, Collins
7. *Nine Lives: In Search of the Sacred in Modern India*  
William Dalrymple, Bloomsbury
10. *Victoria & Abdul*  
Shrabani Basu, Rupa

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

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